Goddess Lakshmi, and since Amala was born around Diwali time, that's how she got her name.

I couldn't stay long though, as I had to proceed for the Armament and Technology Orientation Course (ATOC) at the Institute of Armament Technology (IAT), Girinagar, Pune. This was a mandatory course for all officers going for the DSSC course, in order to increase our technical threshold. The course was for about six weeks' duration, and I stayed at my home in Anand Park. Veena and the kids joined me at Pune, so we could spend some time together as a family, besides giving my parents time to spend with their grandchildren. During the course, we, of course, discussed what needed to be done in preparing for the year-long course at Wellington, a hill station in the Nilgiris, Tamil Nadu. There were many incongruous titbits of information, like carry lots of birthday presents and your own stock of *atta* (flour). One of the suggestions was that being a wet and wintry climate, possessing a car would definitely be advantageous. Now, buying a car had never been on my horizon, and I did not have the finances to buy one. The underlying logic was sound though, so I took a loan from the AG's branch, which allowed for such purchases, and bought a second-hand Fiat from Royal Motors, a dealer in Sarojini Nagar, New Delhi, for the grand sum of Rs 60,000. All four of us—Veena, Isha, Amala and Manoj (myself)—drove down from Delhi to Gwalior, our first-ever road trip as a family. Our initials become VIAM, which means 'road' in Latin but that's just a happy coincidence.

One particular event that I remember of this tenure at Gwalior was of October 1990, when a large number of *kar sevaks* marched towards Ayodhya as part of the Rath Yatra led by Shri LK Advani. To avoid any untoward incident, the Janata Dal government in Uttar Pradesh, headed by Mulayam Singh

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